

NBA Roster Optimization Using Mixed-Integer Linear Programming: Comparative Analysis of Different Algorithmic Approaches

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Abstract

In this research project, Mixed-Integer Linear Programming is used in an attempt to solve the issue of NBA roster construction with position, salary, and minute constraints. A binary integer formula which selects a combination of 15 players that maximizes a composite player-value metric is formulated using empirically derived weights from Pearson's correlation analysis across the 2025-2026 NBA season. This method will be compared against a greedy baseline and a value-per-dollar heuristic to demonstrate how the MILP objective score improves over the greedy and heuristic algorithms. Specifically, we examine if the MILP roster has characteristics similar to the 2025-2026 NBA championship team. This shows that while MILP performs correctly as a constrained optimizer, the differences from the championship roster show the limitations of additive and statistic-derived objective functions in successfully capturing the non-additive interaction effects. The findings reveal MILP as an effective optimization technique while identifying the metric quality and additivity assumption as the binding constraints on real-world applicability and that MILP has a 50.5% better performance compared to the heuristic algorithm and a 25.7% better performance compared to the greedy algorithm. Additionally, divergence was revealed through 3 out of the 4 predetermined championship principles when the MILP roster was compared against the championship roster.

Keywords: Mixed-Integer Linear Programming, roster optimization, sports analytics, Pearson correlation, combinatorial optimization, JuMP, HiGHS

Introduction

The creation of an optimal NBA roster is representative of a constrained resource allocation problem: a team is required to select a group of players in accordance with a salary floor, salary cap, minute constraints, positional requirements, and roster size, while maximizing a measure of collective player quality. The structure of this problem (binary variables, linear constraints, and a linear objective) makes it a candidate for Mixed-Integer Linear Programming (MILP).

This paper investigates if MILP is able to successfully produce better rosters than simpler algorithms and if rosters optimized under empirically derived player value metrics exhibit structural characteristics that are consistent with real champions. These are two distinct questions that will be explored in this paper.

Research Questions

This paper will go in-depth into two independent research questions:

Algorithm Validity: Is MILP able to find a better roster than greedy and heuristic algorithms under similar constraints and objective functions?

Metric Validity: Are the empirically selected player metrics, weighted by their correlation with team wins in the 2025-26 NBA season, able to successfully produce a roster that has parallel characteristics as the current NBA champions?

Contributions

This paper makes the following contributions:

A MILP formulation of the NBA roster construction problem with salary, positional, and minute constraints which will be implemented in Julia with the JuMP and HiGHS packages.

An empirical methodology for the objective function weight derivation using Pearson's correlation analysis across 26 candidate player metrics.

A comparative analysis of three algorithmic approaches (MILP, Greedy, ValuePerDollar Heuristic) to quantify the optimality gap between approaches.

A structured comparison of the MILP roster against the 2025-26 NBA championship roster across predefined roster construction principles with explicit discussion of where and why divergence occurs.

Background and Related Concepts

Mixed-Integer Linear Programming

Mixed-Integer Linear Programming (MILP) is a type of optimization method where linear programming and integer variables are integrated, assisting with modeling complex problems that include continuous and discrete decision variables in order to address multiple objectives and constraints.

In this model, branch-and-bound is used as the solving method to reveal the optimal solution. The main problem regarding the overall creation of the team is broken down into smaller subproblems which forms a tree-like structure. In this tree, each node represents a partial solution. For each node, the algorithm computes an upper or lower bound on the best possible solution within this subproblem. If this bound is worse than the current best-known solution, then the node isn't explored further. By eliminating branches that cannot yield better solutions than the current best, the algorithm reduces the number of computations which enhances efficiency.

Greedy and Heuristic Algorithms

A greedy algorithm is an efficient optimization algorithm that picks the most favorable option at a certain point. While this algorithm is fast and efficient, it does not guarantee the best possible solution in that case as it really doesn't consider the long-term effects of any decision.

A heuristic algorithm is an algorithm that gives feasible solutions of each instance of the problem to be optimized at a certain point. For this project, this algorithm sorts players by dividing their composite score by their salary to produce their value-per-dollar score. This prioritizes salary efficiency over raw statistics.

Compared to MILP which evaluates the global solution space using the branch-and-bound method to find the optimal combination, these algorithms select the next available player as long as they satisfy the set constraints.

Pearson's Correlation Coefficient

Each of the statistics were assigned a Pearson's r value to measure how closely they align with the success of NBA teams. This coefficient measures the linear relationship between two variables and is assigned on a scale between -1 and +1. A coefficient closer to +1 represents a strong positive relationship between two variables while a coefficient closer to -1 represents a strong negative relationship between two variables.

For this project, a Pearson's r value close to +1 indicates the averages of that statistic for every team and the total wins for each NBA team have a strong positive correlation with each other. A Pearson's r value close to -1 indicates the averages of that statistic for every team and the total wins for each NBA team have a strong negative correlation with each other. A Pearson's r value close to 0 suggests that there is no real correlation between the statistic and the total team wins.

Pearson's r assumes a linear relationship between player metrics and team wins. Non-linear effects between statistics and team success are therefore not captured and might limit the accuracy of the derived weights.

Player Value Metrics

- PPG (Points Per Game) was selected as for a team to succeed, it is extremely important that from an offensive standpoint their potential is maximized. Compared to the other statistics that had a similar Pearson's r value, field-goals made and free-throws made, this made more sense to select as this better capture how good a player is offensively, whereas these other two statistics could depend solely on the amount of these shots a player takes, not properly capturing how efficient they are offensively. While the absolute value of this Pearson's r isn't necessarily high, this is necessary to include to maximize the offensive potential of the team.
- PER (Player Efficiency Rating) was chosen as this statistic captures a basketball player's statistical contributions into one number, giving a proper measure of how efficient a player is given the amount of minutes they play. Compared to the other statistics that had a similar Pearson's r value, offensive and defensive rebounds per game, this made more sense to select as this better capture how good a player is offensively, whereas these other two statistics mainly capture how effective a player is by themselves, not what they can contribute to a team. While the absolute value of this Pearson's r isn't necessarily high, this is the best statistic for maximizing the efficiency of a team.
- WS (Win Shares) was chosen as this had the highest Pearson's r value out all statistics and this estimates the total wins a player has contributed in a season with their performance. If the model selects players who overall contribute to more wins then the team has a better chance of succeeding.
- G (Games Played) was selected as this had the second highest Pearson's r coefficient and it is important that the final team is durable and is able to play as many games as possible.
- eFG% (Efficient Field-Goal Percentage) was chosen as alongside being one of the statistics with the highest Pearson's r coefficient, this is an adjusted version of the regular field-goal percentage as this weights three-pointers more than two-pointers. This statistic will also capture the effectiveness of a player offensively.
- FPG (Fouls Per Game) was selected as this was one of the statistics that had a negative Pearson's r value. Also, considering that the absolute value of this Pearson's r coefficient is fairly significant this means to some extent, if the model limits the amount of fouls per player then this can lead to a more effective team.
- TPG (Turnovers Per Game) was selected as this statistic had the lowest Pearson's r coefficient out of any statistic. Similar to Fouls Per Game, if the model limits the amount of turnovers a player commits, this can maximize the potential of the team.

Selected Metrics, Pearson's R Values, and Derived Weights

Metric	Description	Pearson's R	Weight (w)
PPG	Points Per Game	0.069	0.020
PER	Player Efficiency Rating	0.165	0.045
WS	Win Shares	0.937	0.278
G	Games Played	0.663	0.197
eFG%	Efficient Field-Goal Percentage	0.458	0.136
FPG	Fouls Per Game	-0.477	-0.142
TPG	Turnovers Per Game	-0.599	-0.178

Data Collection and Cleaning

Data Sources

Per-game statistics for all 30 NBA teams were obtained from Basketball-Reference.com. Full source URLs are listed in the References section.

Cleaning Decisions

For each of the raw datasets, a minimum threshold of 30 games was set. If any player played less than 30 games, the query that was written would delete them from the new dataset formed.

After this process was performed, all of the cleaned datasets were combined in BigQuery. The combined dataset had a total of 371 players from 30 different teams.

Missing Value Treatment

In each of the datasets, there were a couple of players that never shot a three-pointer the entire season, leading to their three-point percentage being of value null.

Considering that three-point percentage was one of the statistics that this model looked to maximize, this would put these players at a disadvantage of being selected even if they would help to produce an optimal roster. As a result, to account for this every player who had a null three-point percentage was assigned the mean of the entire column.

Metric Selection via Pearson's R

Statistic	Pearson's R Value
WS (Win Shares)	0.937
Games Played	0.663
Field-Goal Percentage	0.578
Two-Point Percentage	0.563
Efficient Field-Goal Percentage	0.458
Three-Point Percentage	0.440
Total Rebounds Per Game	0.276
Free-Throw Percentage	0.275
Defensive Rebounds Per Game	0.235
Player Efficiency Rating	0.165
Offensive Rebounds Per Game	0.148
Field-Goals Made Per Game	0.070
Points Per Game	0.069
Free-Throws Made Per Game	0.051
Blocks Per Game	0.043
Steals Per Game	0.041
Three-Pointers Made Per Game	0.036
Free-Throws Attempted Per Game	0.017
Two-Pointers Made Per Game	-0.017
Three-Pointers Attempted Per Game	-0.095
Assists	-0.095
Two-Pointers Attempted Per Game	-0.162
Field-Goals Attempted Per Game	-0.226
Minutes Played Per Game	-0.245
Fouls Per Game	-0.477
Turnovers Per Game	-0.599

Model Foundation

Decision Variables

For each player, a binary decision variable was created that would keep track of whether the model selected this player. This would be indexed by the players array.

Let $selected_i \in \{0,1\}$, $\forall i \in \text{Players}$

Objective Function

For the objective function, each of the statistics r value was weighted based on their precedence compared to the other statistics there. Then each of the weights were multiplied by their respective statistic and these were all added in an attempt to maximize the function.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Max } \sum_{p=1}^P & weight_{ppg} * ppg[p] + weight_{per} * per[p] + weight_{ws} * ws[p] + weight_{games} \\ & * games[p] + weight_{eFG\%} * eFG\%[p] + weight_{fouls} * fouls[p] \\ & + weight_{turnovers} * turnovers[p] \end{aligned}$$

Constraints

Since we are attempting to create a team realistic to how an NBA team operates, there are certain constraints that we must adhere to.

Salary Floor

In the 2025-2026 NBA season, the salary floor for every NBA team was approximately \$139 M dollars. This was implemented in the model.

$$\sum_{p=1}^P salary[p] * selected[p] \geq 139$$

Salary Cap

In the 2025-2026 NBA season, the salary cap for every NBA team was approximately \$155 M dollars. This was implemented in the model.

$$\sum_{p=1}^P salary[p] * selected[p] \leq 155$$

Minutes Constraint

The minimum amount of minutes in an NBA rotation is 220 while the maximum amount of minutes in an NBA rotation is 240.

$$\sum_{p=1}^P minutes[p] * selected[p] \geq 220$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P minutes[p] * selected[p] \leq 240$$

Position Constraint

The minimum amount of players that there can be in a certain position is 2 while the maximum amount of players that there can be in a certain position is 3.

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "PG" \geq 2$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "PG" \leq 3$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "SG" \geq 2$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "SG" \leq 3$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "SF" \geq 2$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "SF" \leq 3$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "PF" \geq 2$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "PF" \leq 3$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "C" \geq 2$$

$$\sum_{p=1}^P selected[p] \text{ if } position[p] == "C" \leq 3$$

Roster Size

The amount of players that an NBA team must roster is 15.

$$\sum_{p=1}^P \text{selected}[p] = 15$$

Implementation

The model was implemented in Julia using the JuMP package as this package allows the programmer to describe an optimization problem in a cleaner way without necessarily worrying about how it is solved and then the HiGHS package would be used to actually compute the answer. HiGHS (version 1.14.0) was used as the solver.

Results and Discussion

Algorithm Comparison (RQ1)

The algorithm comparison table underneath displays the final outputs of all three algorithms using the same CSV file with the same weights applied for the objective function.

The MILP model produced an objective score of 235.0073, outperforming the heuristic function by 50.2% and the greedy algorithm by 25.7%, which was unsuccessful in producing a 15-man roster due to cap exhaustion.

The formula to calculate this difference was: $((\text{MILP} - \text{baseline}) / \text{baseline}) \times 100$.

While the statistics of the players the MILP model and the heuristic algorithm selected were somewhat similar to each other, the MILP model selected 2 players with point averages of at least 20 and the win shares of the players in the MILP model were generally higher than the ones selected in the heuristic algorithm.

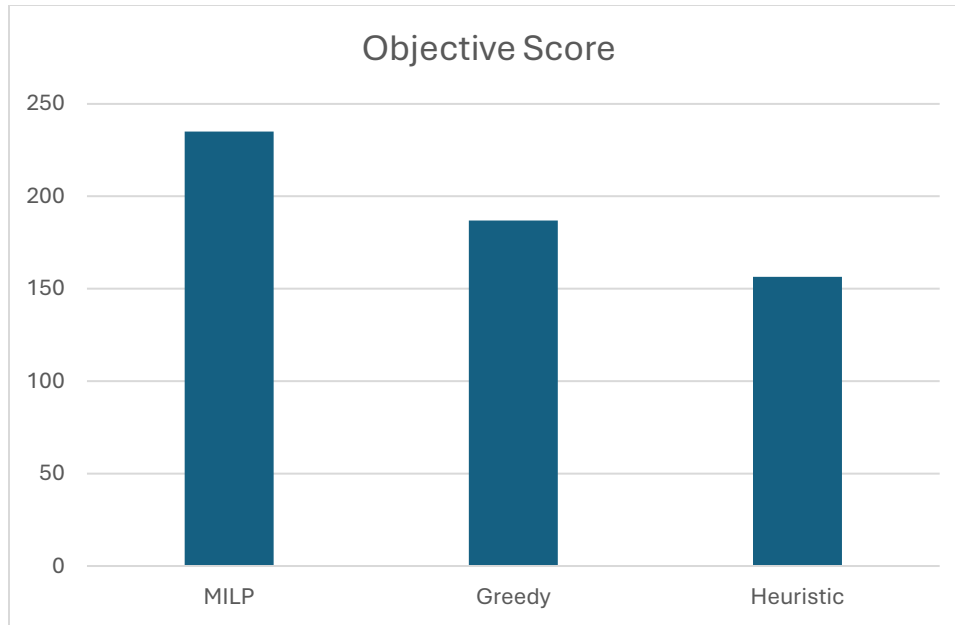
As a result, the MILP model turned out to be much more successful than the heuristic algorithm.

Algorithm Comparison – Objective Score, Feasibility, Solve Time

Algorithm	Objective Score	Players Selected	Solve Time	Optimality
MILP	235.0073	"Carter Bryant" "Clint Capela" "Gary Payton II" + 12 Other Players	0.69 s	Certified Optimal
Heuristic	156.4579	"Caleb Love" "Branden Carlson" "Tony Bradley" + 12 Other Players	5.0 ms	Not Guaranteed
Greedy	186.9351	"Shai Gilgeous-Alexander" "Kevin Durant" "Amen Thompson" + 7 Other Players	4.0 ms	Infeasible

The greedy algorithm's failure to select a valid roster is a very meaningful finding. Since this algorithm sorted players by the composite score calculated for them, the players at the top were appended to the selected players. The six players who were selected first (Shai Gilgeous-Alexander, Kevin Durant, Amen Thompson, Mikal Bridges) ended up occupying 127.6 M of the 155 M salary cap (82.3%). This ended up leaving insufficient cap space to fill the remaining roster spots and illustrated why unconstrained local optimization will fail in cap-constrained environments and the need for global combinatorial search.

Objective Score Comparison: MILP vs Heuristic vs Greedy



Scalability Analysis

To assess the scalability, the MILP model was run on player pools of different sizes by subsetting the dataset. The scalability analysis table reports the solve time and objective score as a function of the pool size.

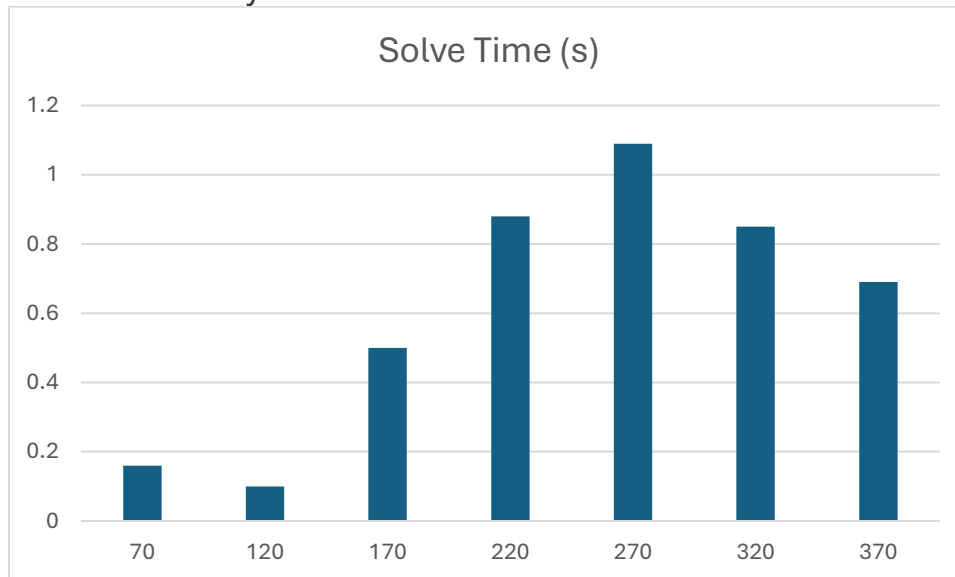
Scalability Analysis – Solve Time and Objective Score by Pool Size

Pool Size (n)	Solve Time (s)	Objective Score	Status
70	0.16 s	196.9690	Optimal
120	0.10 s	208.2850	Optimal
170	0.50 s	221.4831	Optimal
220	0.88 s	228.8261	Optimal
270	1.09 s	232.3728	Optimal
320	0.85 s	232.8415	Optimal
370	0.69 s	235.0073	Optimal

As the pool size increases, the solve time doesn't move in a fixed direction. Rather, it unpredictably oscillates either upward or downward with each increase by 50 in the pool size. From pool size 270 to pool size 370, we see the overall objective score decrease at an increasing rate, meaning that the overall objective score this function can achieve is approximately around these values as this is where it plateaus.

Additionally, regarding the solve times for each of the sizes the non-monotonic finding stands out with the solve time constantly decreasing then increasing. This can be accredited to the tree-like structure that is formed by the branch-and-bound algorithm which will most likely create an uneven tree balance. Hence, when making a decision down the tree, a lot of data can be discarded at once, leading to the optimal solution much quicker. Also, as the player pool size increases, the LP relaxation becomes tighter as there are more branches for the model to explore and with the solution possibly becoming more obvious, it will attempt to eliminate as many of them as possible without exploring them.

Solve Time vs Player Pool Size



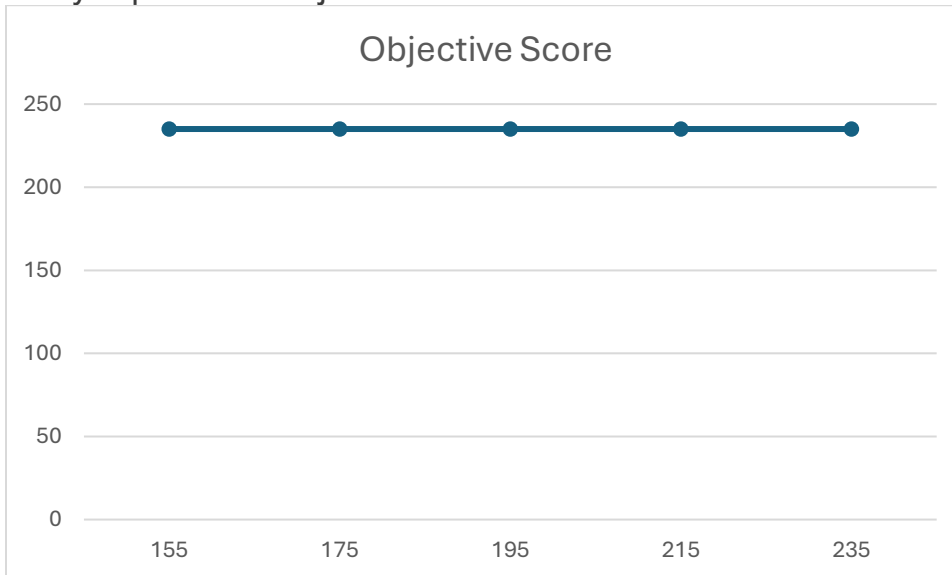
Sensitivity Analysis – Salary Cap Relaxation

To test how the objective score changes with the salary, from the official NBA salary cap (\$155 M) this was iterated by \$20 M each time until there was a plateau in the objective score for multiple values. For each increase in the salary cap level, the objective score stayed at 235.0073. This occurs as the model already selects the highest-value players available in the pool. Additional cap space cannot further improve the roster as there are no remaining unselected players whose inclusion would increase the objective score.

Table

Salary Cap Level (M)	Objective Score
155	235.0073
175	235.0073
195	235.0073
215	235.0073
235	235.0073

Salary Cap Level vs Objective Score



Championship Roster Comparison (RQ2)

The table underneath compares the roster produced by the MILP model against the 2025-2026 NBA champion across four predefined statistics. These statistics were predetermined before running the model.

Championship Roster Structural Comparison Across Predetermined Statistics

Principle	Championship Team	MILP Roster	Match?
Anchor player WS	AVG: 5.0 MAX: 9.5	AVG: 3.8 MAX: 15.2	No
Salary Concentration	Total: 204.7 MAX: 53.1	Total: 139.0 MAX: 38.3	No
Average PER	AVG: 16.0	AVG: 16.2	Yes
Positional anchor pos.	PG: 2 SG: 3 SF: 3 PF: 1 C: 4	PG: 3 SG: 3 SF: 3 PF: 3 C: 3	No

While the average WS of the championship team is slightly greater than the MILP roster, there are differences in the overall WS of the players in each roster as the MILP roster is top-heavy (3 players with >6 WS, 1 players with >15 WS, 12 players with <5 WS) while the championship team is more balanced (6 players with >5 WS). The salary concentration of the championship team and MILP roster are somewhat similar to each other as both are fairly similar to each other (Championship team has 6 players with salary over 10 M and MILP roster has 4 players with salary over 10 M). However, the overall salary averages and the total salary of the players differ substantially. Overall, the PER's of both the MILP roster and the championship team are fairly similar to each other as they are both balanced with the same values (MILP roster has 2 values considered to be outliers). However, the positional anchors for both teams differ substantially.

It must be noted however that this overall divergence from the championship roster does not necessarily mean algorithmic failure as HiGHS certifies the MILP solution is mathematically optimal in regard to the objective function and constraints. Instead, these findings reveal a limitation of the objective function as the additive structure required by MILP is unable to capture the interaction effects between players (the chemistry between players that make their combinations more valuable than others).

This is consistent with the known limitations of box-score-derived metrics in sports analytics. While PER and WS are strongly correlated with team wins, they are unable to capture defensive value, lineup spacing effects, or the disproportionate impact of superstar players in high-leverage playoff situations.

Limitations and Future Work

Additive Objective Function

The MILP formulation assumes that the total roster value equals the sum of individual player scores and this is a structural simplification required by the linear nature of MILP. Realistically, player interaction effects have a significant effect on basketball outcomes as a player's value can change based on their other teammates. The ability to capture these effects would require a much different modeling approach which is beyond the scope of this study.

Metric Quality

The metrics that were included in the objective function were taken from the available statistics for the public to view. While the metrics were empirically chosen based on their correlation to team wins compared to the other statistics in the pool, they do have some limitations. PER overweighs players with higher offensive usage rate, WS is unable to precisely capture defensive contributions, and games played reflects more on player durability rather than their true quality. Modern tracking metrics such as RAPTOR or EPM may be stronger predictors of winning but are not publicly available.

Single-Season Scope

This model only operates regarding the 2025-2026 NBA season. To construct a real NBA roster, multi-year salary commitments, contract extensions, and draft considerations that span multiple seasons are widely considered. The ability to extend this model into a multiple year MILP model would require decision variables that span multiple seasons and this would introduce greater complexity that currently cannot be handled.

Additionally, in this study only per-game statistics were considered rather than the full season totals for each player. In future iterations of this work these statistics may be considered here.

Constraint Simplification

Several real-world constraints that are complex to mathematically model are not included such as player injury risk, availability, no-trade clauses, Bird rights and contract extensions, two-way contracts, and trade exceptions. The exclusion of these constraints means that this model constructs rosters that are not realistically achievable by an actual NBA office. For example, the champions of the 2025-2026 NBA season had a total payroll of \$204.7 M. This is approximately \$49.7 M more than the official salary cap of \$155 M. This roster construction was made possible due to bird rights, trade exceptions, etc.

Future Work

Future iterations of this work can improve on this by incorporating modern tracking-based statistics which improve the objective function validity, extending to a multi-season formulation in order to capture the proper contract dynamics, replacing the additive objective with a lineup-based formulation that implements five-man plus-minus data which measures non-additive combination effects, and apply this same MILP structure to other salary-cap constrained sports in order to ensure generalizability.

Conclusion

RQ1, algorithm validity, has been answered affirmatively. Mixed-Integer Linear Programming (MILP) is an effective technique for roster construction under salary cap, positional, and minute constraints. The MILP model was able to achieve an optimal solution in approximately 0.69 seconds and outperformed the heuristic algorithm by 50.5% on the composite objective metric.

RQ2, metric validity, has been answered partially. When compared against the 2025-2026 NBA champion, divergence across 3 of the 4 predefined principles were revealed. This is not necessarily due to algorithmic failure as MILP successfully found the optimal solution to the problem, it is attributable to two structural limitations. The additive objective function is unable to capture interaction effects and the box score statistics that were empirically selected via Pearson's correlation do not fully represent the complex determinants of championship-level team performance.

Considering both research questions, the findings suggest that MILP is a sound and well-suited optimization technique and the primary constraint on real-world applicability is not necessarily algorithmic but more in the quality and structure of the objective function. Future iterations of this work that incorporate tracking-based metrics or lineup-level data would help to reduce this gap.

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